

overthrew the government of President General Fulgencio Batista.

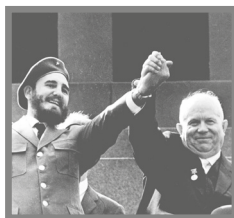
Trade embargo

The US accepted Castro as ruler of Cuba, in spite of his communist leanings, and had a large economic presence in Cuba. However, Castro began to break the American hold on the economy, nationalizing all industry without compensation. In response, the US imposed a sweeping trade embargo, so Castro turned to the Soviet Union for support. Fearing communist expansion, the US tried to topple Cuba's government with the failed Bay of Pigs invasion in April 1961, involving CIA-backed Cuban exiles.

Also in 1961, the US deployed 15 nuclear-tipped Jupiter missiles in Turkey, in readiness to strike against the USSR should the need arise. Turkey shared a border with the Soviet Union, so this was viewed as a direct threat to Soviet territory.

An ultimatum

Khrushchev came under pressure from Soviet hard-liners to take a tough stance. This, and the desire to defend his Cuban ally from American aggression, led him to install missiles in Cuba that were capable of carrying nuclear warheads. On October 14, 1962, photographs taken by a U-2 spy plane showed nuclear weapon sites being built by the Soviets. Kennedy's military advisers



Cuban president Fidel Castro

and Soviet leader Nikita Khrushchev hold up their joined hands in a show of unity on an official state visit Castro made to Moscow in May 1963.

sought an immediate attack on the missile sites, but Kennedy favored a naval blockade of Cuba to prevent the installation of more missiles. He issued an ultimatum to Khrushchev to withdraw and informed the world that nuclear war was an imminent possibility. Meanwhile, Khrushchev ordered the captains of Soviet ships to hold their course for Cuban ports.

Breaking the deadlock

Frantic diplomacy behind the scenes led to a deal that broke the deadlock: Kennedy agreed to remove missiles from Turkey in secret if Khrushchev dismantled all nuclear weapons in Cuba. The Soviet leader agreed—only if America would also abort its plan to invade Cuba.

On October 28, Khrushchev ordered his ships to turn around—a defining moment of the Cold War. The superpowers became more cautious, and the threat of nuclear war began to diminish. ■

John Fitzgerald Kennedy



The 35th president of the US, John Fitzgerald Kennedy (1917–1963) was the first Roman Catholic and, at 43, the youngest man ever to be elected

to that office. As president, Kennedy brought a fresh and youthful style to politics, calling his program the “New Frontier.” This included a challenge to venture into outer space and to eliminate poverty. His administration quickly won popular support.

Kennedy's years in power were marked in foreign affairs by Cold War tension. His greatest test was the Cuban Missile Crisis of 1962, where his firm stance against Russia brought him even greater popularity.

His ambitious domestic reforms, however, on issues such as welfare and civil rights, were increasingly blocked by Congress.

While he was campaigning for the next presidential election, JFK was assassinated by Lee Harvey Oswald in Dallas, Texas, on November 22, 1963. Kennedy's death was a shock and a tragedy for Americans, at a time when tensions were just starting to ease between the United States and Russia.